

THE THIRD INSTANCE

A complete worked excavation, start to finish — including the exact point where it gets hard, and exactly what to do when it does.

WHY THIS ONE IS DIFFERENT

The other two resources taught you why an anchor behavior matters, and how to test one. This one shows you what actually happens when you go looking for it — including the part almost every writer hits: two good instances, and a third that will not come.

What follows is a single excavation, start to finish, on a character built just for this walkthrough. Watch the whole arc. When you hit the stuck point — this session, or a later one — you will already know exactly what to try.

THE CHARACTER

A writer is working on a family drama. There is a supporting character, Marcus — an older brother, a business owner, someone the writer has a strong feel for but has never actually excavated. Here is what happens when they do.

DISCOVERY — NAMING WHAT YOU THINK YOU KNOW

The writer's first answer is a label: "Marcus is controlling." The coach does not accept it — a label is not a behavior. Pushed further: "He always wants to know where everyone is." Closer, but still soft. Pushed once more, something concrete arrives.

THE BEHAVIOR, AS FOUND

"If someone doesn't pick up his call on the first ring, he calls again immediately."

That is a real candidate. Specific, visible, something a camera would catch. But a candidate is not a confirmed anchor behavior yet — that takes the next two stages.

TESTING — DOES IT PASS?

Run it against the four requirements before spending time chasing instances.

- ✓ Specific Calling back immediately on a missed first ring is a concrete action — not a trait like "controlling."
- ✓ Visible A camera would catch it — the phone, the ring, the redial, all on screen.
- ? Recurring Not yet confirmed. This is exactly what Validation exists to prove.
- ? Consequential Plausible — but only real instances will confirm it actually matters to the story.

Two checks pass immediately. Two are still open. Move to Validation to close them.

VALIDATION — FINDING THE INSTANCES

Two come fast.

INSTANCE ONE

With his teenage daughter — she doesn't answer within three rings, and he is calling again before the ringback tone even finishes.

INSTANCE TWO

With his business partner — mid-meeting, the partner steps out to take another call. Marcus calls back before the partner has even hung up the first one.

Two instances. But here is where it stalls. A third example will not come. Every other idea the writer reaches for feels like a restatement of the first two — not a genuinely new instance.

THE STUCK POINT

This is normal — not a sign the behavior is wrong, just a sign the search needs a different angle. There are three reliable ways to find a third instance when the obvious ones run out. Here are the first two, applied live.

Technique One

SCAN BY RELATIONSHIP TYPE

The two instances so far both come from people Marcus is close to and responsible for — his daughter, his business partner. Real patterns usually surface with people outside that circle too. What about a stranger? An authority figure? Someone he has no real claim over at all?

Technique Two

SCAN BY STAKES

Both instances so far are low-pressure — an unanswered phone, a slow ringback tone. What happens to this exact pattern when the stakes are real? Not whether he still does it — what it looks like when it actually matters.

The writer tries stakes. And here it comes.

INSTANCE THREE

Marcus has an estranged brother he hasn't spoken to in three years. Their mother is hospitalized. Marcus calls his brother's phone eleven times in twenty minutes — past the point where he told himself he'd stop, past the point where anyone would still expect an answer.

Same pattern. Same behavior. Except now the stakes are real, and the pattern does not bend under pressure — it gets louder.

Technique Three — Keep This One in Reserve

THE REVERSAL TEST

For when the first two do not crack it: picture the one moment your character does not do the behavior. What would that cost them? If the absence would be surprising — if not calling back would mean admitting something they cannot afford to admit — you are standing right next to the real pattern. That missing moment often turns out to be the instance you were looking for.

CONFIRMATION — IS IT REAL, OR IS IT THE PLOT?

One last check before locking it in. Does this behavior actually matter to relationships, decisions, where the story goes — or is it just something the story needed him to do once?

The daughter has started hiding her phone; she has stopped believing space is possible with him. The business partner has started screening his calls. And the brother, when he finally answers on the eleventh call, says only: "Don't call me like this again." Three relationships, one behavior, real consequences in every one. This one holds.

THE ANCHOR BEHAVIOR

Marcus calls again immediately if someone doesn't answer right away — with his daughter, his business partner, his estranged brother — regardless of whether the moment actually calls for patience.

QUICK REFERENCE — THREE WAYS TO FIND INSTANCE THREE

- 1 Scan by relationship type. Family, stranger, authority figure, someone with no real claim on them at all — has the behavior shown up outside the people you have already used?
- 2 Scan by stakes. Find the same pattern at low pressure, then look for it again when the pressure is real. The pattern that survives real stakes is the one worth keeping.
- 3 The reversal test. Picture the one moment they do not do it. What would that cost them? The missing moment is often the instance you needed.

NEXT

You have watched the whole arc once, stuck point and all. Now it is yours — open your coaching session and go find your own third instance.